WRITING GUIDE

THE WRITING PROCESS

Before you begin writing:

▶ STEP 1: Brainstorm for ideas

- Write down all the ideas you can think of.
- Don't worry about whether the idea is relevant.
- Don't worry about grammar or spelling.
- You can write in your own language.

▶ STEP 2: Organise your ideas

- Decide which ideas to keep, and cross out the others.
- Group similar ideas together.
- Put the groups in order according to a writing plan.

▶ STEP 3: Focus on language

- Think of words and expressions you will need in your work.

▶ STEP 4: Write a first draft

- Write in pencil. Leave wide margins for notes. Leave space between lines for additions and corrections.
- Write quickly. Don't worry about neatness or accuracy.
- If you can't think of a word in English, write it in your own language.
- If you can't spell a word, write it any way you can. Then check the word in a dictionary when you have finished.

TOPIC: Living in another country

(A) Improves understanding of local customs, way of life.

(C) Take a basic course - language.

~~Difficult to do on your own.~~

(B) Student exchange programmes – secondary school or university.

~~Good idea to keep a diary while there.~~

(B) Work abroad – can be arranged in advance.

(A) Best way to learn language.

(A) Can get to know local people, make friends.

(C) Look at maps, learn where main cities are.

~~City centres – expensive to live in.~~

(C) Read – country's history, traditions.

Group A – Advantages of living in another country

Group B – Ways to arrange living in another country

Group C – How to prepare for living in another country

▶ STEP 5: Check your work

- Use the Writer's Checklist on this page to improve your work.

▶ STEP 6: Write a final draft

- When you are satisfied with your work, copy it neatly onto a clean sheet of paper.
- Write in pen or type on the computer.
- Be sure to include all your corrections.
- Leave a margin on the left-hand side.
- Make sure your paragraphs are clearly indicated.

NOTE:

You can indicate the beginning of a paragraph by:

1. indenting (moving the first word of the paragraph to the right).
2. skipping a line before beginning a new paragraph. Each paragraph begins at the left-hand margin.

Both styles are correct, but be consistent in your writing. The indented style is preferred for informal letters.

If you are ~~planing~~ planning to live in another country, you should take a course in the language. This will help you speak with the local people and ~~may you~~ you may eventually become fluent. It is also a good idea to read ~~on~~ about the country's history and traditions ~~so that~~ in order to learn some basic facts about ~~her~~ it before you ~~will live~~ live there.

WRITER'S CHECKLIST

CONTENT

Did I...

- ☐ begin with a suitable opening sentence?
- ☐ present my ideas clearly?
- ☐ use relevant details and examples to explain my ideas?
- ☐ support my ideas with details and examples (opinion, for and against essay)?
- ☐ end with a suitable closing sentence?
- ☐ use pronouns to refer to the nouns in the paragraph?
- ☐ use connectors to link my ideas?

LANGUAGE

Did I...

- ☐ check my grammar?
- ☐ check my spelling?
- ☐ check word order?
- ☐ use correct punctuation?
- ☐ use capital letters correctly?
- ☐ use adjectives correctly?

ORGANISATION

Did I...

- ☐ use suitable connectors?
- ☐ present the information in a logical order?

CONNECTORS

Connectors are linking words which join ideas and show how those ideas are related to one another.

Fast food is delicious. ***However****, it's not very healthy.* (to express a contrast)

Many people have stopped eating fast food ***because*** *they are worried about their weight.* (to describe a reason)

For this reason*, some fast-food restaurants have begun serving healthy, low-fat salads.* (to describe a result)

They also help us to organise our writing and make it easy for the reader to follow.

In general*, I think that paparazzi go too far in taking photos of celebrities.* ***To begin with****, they do dangerous or cruel things in order to make stars angry and get an embarrassing shot.* ***Moreover****, they try to catch stars when they are at home or on holiday by secretly taking photos from rooftops or trees.* ***It can also be argued that*** *famous people must accept the fact that they are always in the public eye.* ***Nevertheless****, I believe that celebrities should be able to decide when and where to be photographed.* ***To sum up****, even celebrities have a right to privacy.*

Study the chart of connectors and phrases below.

PURPOSE	EXAMPLES
to add points on the same topic	and / in addition / furthermore / moreover / what's more / besides / also / too / as well as
to express a contrast	but / however / nevertheless / yet / still / although / even if / even though / in spite of / despite
to describe a cause or reason	because (of) / since / due to / one/another reason for…is… / as
to describe a result	so / therefore / consequently / thus / as a result / as a consequence / for this reason / that is why
to show purpose	in order to / so as to / so that / to
to describe similarity	similarly / likewise / in the same way
to express personal opinions	in my opinion / I (strongly) believe (that) / I think/feel (that) / in my view / it seems to me (that) / personally / as I see it
to describe reality	in fact / as a matter of fact / actually / the truth is (that)
to make general statements	in general / generally / as a rule / on the whole
to list points	to begin/start with / in the first place / first of all / firstly, secondly, thirdly / finally / lastly
to give examples	for example / for instance / such as / like / particularly / in particular / especially / (more) specifically
to introduce opposing points	on the one hand / on the other hand / in contrast / contrary to / it can also be argued that / but there are people who say (that)
to show sequence	first / at first / in the beginning / before / next / then / soon / meanwhile / later / after that / afterwards / at last / eventually / finally / in the end
to show time	when / while / before / after / until / as soon as / by the time
to conclude	in conclusion / to sum up / in short

WRITING A PARAGRAPH

A paragraph consists of several sentences about a certain topic. It has got the following parts:

1. a **topic sentence** which gives the main idea of the paragraph
2. **supporting sentences** which add reasons, details and examples
3. a **concluding sentence** which summarises the main idea (not always necessary)

The parts of a paragraph should flow logically. The paragraph must be easy to understand. You can accomplish this by:

1. using pronouns to refer back to the nouns in the text.
2. using connectors to show the connections between ideas (see the chart on page 132).

PLAN:

Topic sentence

Supporting sentences

Concluding sentence

More and more families are moving from the suburbs into the city centres. **First of all**, living in the city means living near your place of work. **Secondly**, you are likely to be a short distance away from high-quality cultural activities and entertainment, for both parents and children. **Thirdly**, it is easier and takes less time to maintain a flat than a large house with a garden. **In short**, living in the city can provide a convenient, enjoyable way of life.

WRITING AN ESSAY

An essay consists of several paragraphs about a topic. There are many different kinds of essays, but they have all got the same basic plan:

1. THE OPENING

The opening is a general presentation of the topic. Try to start your essay with an opening that will catch your reader's interest. Here are some ideas:

1. **Write a short anecdote about real or imaginary events.**

   "Let's go to the theatre," said Leonard to his wife.
   "That would be lovely, dear," she answered, "but it took me an hour and a half to get home from work. I haven't got the energy to go back into the city tonight."

2. **Begin with one or more questions.**

   Do you stay home night after night because there's nothing to do? Do you spend entire weekends working in the garden? There may be a better way of life just around the corner.

3. **Begin with an unidentified pronoun to arouse the reader's curiosity.**

   It means an end to sitting in traffic jams. It means freedom from spending all weekend working in the garden. Living in the city may be just the change you need.

If you can't think how to begin, don't worry. Go on to the body of the essay. You can always write the opening later. The important thing is to keep going.

2. THE BODY

The body has got one or more paragraphs which develop the topic. When you were preparing to write, you brainstormed for ideas (see page 130). Then you chose ideas to use and put these ideas into groups in a logical order. Use these groups of ideas to write the body of the essay. Each group of ideas will become a separate paragraph.

3. THE CLOSING

The closing is a paragraph which summarises the main idea or presents a conclusion. In some cases, the closing may be similar to the opening but presented in different words. It should always leave the reader with a strong impression.

In conclusion, if you want to improve the quality of your life, then the city, with its theatres, parks and restaurants, is the place to be.

WRITING A FOR AND AGAINST ESSAY

When we write a for and against essay, we present both sides of an issue and conclude by supporting one of the sides. Look at the topic below. Then study the plan and read the model.

TOPIC:

Write a for and against essay discussing the advantages and disadvantages of installing automatic cash machines in schools.

PLAN:

MODEL: Do ATMs Belong in Schools?

Opening
Introduction to the issue

Many secondary schools in the USA have recently installed automatic teller machines, or ATMs. This is convenient for students who need cash. However, schools may not be the right place for ATMs.

Body
Presentation of the side the writer agrees with

On the one hand, ATMs can help students who have left their lunch money at home or who have forgotten to bring money for a school trip. In addition, schools can charge money for using the ATM. This money can be used to pay for school activities.

Presentation of the side the writer disagrees with

On the other hand, having ATMs at school encourages teenagers to spend money impulsively by making cash easily available. It also highlights the differences between students who can constantly take out cash, and those from homes with less money. Worst of all, it can increase theft in schools because students will carry more cash.

Conclusion
Writer's opinion

In conclusion, I believe that ATMs in schools cause more problems than they solve. In my opinion, school should be for learning, not for spending.

USEFUL LANGUAGE

On the one hand, ...	Moreover, ...	In my opinion, ...
On the other hand, ...	Furthermore, ...	In short, ...
On the whole, ...	In addition, ...	To sum up, ...
It is true that ...	Worst of all, ...	In conclusion, ...
Firstly, ...	Also, ...	
Secondly, ...	I believe that ...	

WRITING A NARRATIVE

Writing a narrative is like telling a story. Look at the topic below. Then study the plan and read the model.

TOPIC:

Write a narrative about a crime.

PLAN:

Opening
The setting – main characters, when and where the story takes place, introduction to the situation / problem

Body
Plot development
Events in the story

Closing
End of the story, how the problem is solved

MODEL: Surprise!

It was ten o'clock in the morning and the street was fairly empty. Stan and Fred watched an old lady who was slowly walking along. During the past three weeks, they had stolen the handbags of several old ladies in the area, and they were sure that this time it would be just as easy.

The boys waited until the woman reached the corner. Then Stan went over and asked her for directions. Meanwhile Fred came from behind and tried to grab her bag. Suddenly, the woman pushed Stan to the ground and began to hit Fred with her bag. This certainly wasn't part of the plan!

Fred decided the best thing to do was escape. He turned and ran … straight into the arms of two policemen. The police had noticed the thefts in the area and had set a trap for the thieves. And the old woman? She was really a policewoman!

USEFUL LANGUAGE

Time expressions

It all began when ...	when	as soon as	yesterday
It was a cold day ...	while	by the time	all night
before I knew it	before	until	a week later
suddenly	after	during	last summer

Expressions of sequence

first	in the beginning	meanwhile	finally
at first	to begin with	later	in the end
then	next	at last	

WRITING AN OPINION ESSAY

We write opinion essays to convince the reader that our point of view is correct. Look at the topic below. Then study the plan and read the model.

TOPIC:

Write an opinion essay on the topic: School Art Lessons – A Waste of Time?

PLAN:

Opening
Presentation of issue and opinion

Body
Specific reasons and facts to support opinion

Conclusion
Summing up and restatement of opinion

MODEL: School Art Lessons – A Waste of Time?

People sometimes ask whether art should be taught at school. Some say that the time spent on art would be better spent on more useful or academic subjects. However, in my opinion art should be taught at every school.

For one thing, most students enjoy learning art. This is because art is an active lesson that takes them away from lectures and books. Art lessons develop the students' creativity and help them express their ideas and feelings in a different way – using colours instead of words.

In addition, learning art may be useful later in life. For example, young people often discover their artistic talents through art lessons. This can lead to a career in art, such as fine arts, computer graphics or design.

To sum up, art lessons should be part of the school curriculum. Art is an important and enjoyable subject that can benefit every student.

USEFUL LANGUAGE

I think that ...
I believe that ...
In my opinion ...
I love / can't stand / don't mind ...
As for ...
For example ...
Such as ...
As far as I'm concerned ...
Personally, ...
In conclusion, ...
To sum up, ...
In short, ...

WRITING A SUMMARY

When we write a summary, we want to provide the reader with the main points of an article in as few words as possible. Look at the topic below. Then read the original article and the model summary.

TOPIC:

Write a summary of the article, using 50-70 words.

MODEL: Our Brain and the Truth

Mankind has long hoped that science could find a way to determine if a person is telling the truth or lying. In the 20th century, scientists constructed an instrument called the polygraph, which is based on the fact that when people lie, they tend to feel tense. The polygraph keeps a record of certain physiological signs, such as heart rate or blood pressure. When these increase suddenly, a person is probably feeling tense because he or she is lying. However, since the polygraph is really measuring how nervous a person is, its results are not 100% reliable. Now it seems that scientists may have come up with a better idea – the fMRI.

The fMRI is an instrument which uses magnetism to draw a picture of brain activity. In one experiment, researchers asked six people to tell a lie, and five people to tell the truth, measuring them with the fMRI. The results were amazing. The brain activity of the people who lied was radically different than that of those who were telling the truth. For example, lying activated different parts of the brain than truth telling. Furthermore, more parts of the brain were activated in the liars.

Research is still at an early stage. The study was small and tests have not yet determined whether liars can trick the equipment, as some people are able to do with the polygraph. When these tests are done, we may find that the fMRI is the lie detector of the future.

MODEL SUMMARY

The polygraph, which is the lie detector invented in the 20th century, is not completely accurate because it only measures how tense a person is. Consequently, researchers have developed the fMRI, which uses magnetism to measure brain activity. In short, the fMRI has shown that brain activity in liars is different from that in people who are telling the truth. Research on the instrument is continuing.

Includes only important information organised into one cohesive paragraph

TIP:

Leave out less important examples and details and avoid adding your own opinions. Shorten or combine sentences and try to use your own words where possible.

USEFUL LANGUAGE

Being concise

apparently	presently	clearly
consequently	finally	although
if	In short, ...	

WRITING A FORMAL LETTER

When we write a formal letter, we are usually requesting information, applying for a job or course, or writing to complain. Look at the topic below. Then study the plan and read the model.

TOPIC:

Write a formal letter applying for the job of sales assistant in a shop.

PLAN:

MODEL: Job Application

Details
Address of person writing the letter

23 Dayton Lane
Norwood
London SE5 4FB

Date

21 June, 2006

Name and address of person or business being written to

Zarat Fashions
68 Boyers Street
London

Greeting

Dear Sir or Madam,

Opening
Clear reason for writing

I am writing in response to your advertisement for sales assistants in your chain of fashion shops. I would like to apply for a position. I am 18 years old and have just finished secondary school, so I am able to begin work immediately.

Body
Relevant personal details and qualifications

I feel that I would be suitable for this job because I have always had an eye for fashion and feel that I could help customers choose clothes that are suitable for them. I am also a great fan of your fashion line!

I would like to add that I am very patient and have excellent people skills. I am also extremely responsible, organised and hard-working.

Conclusion
Request a response

I look forward to hearing from you in the near future. I have enclosed my CV and would be happy to attend an interview at a time convenient for you. Thank your for considering my application.

Closing

Yours faithfully,

Marianne Edwards

USEFUL LANGUAGE

Greeting
Dear Sir / Madam
Dear Mr / Mrs / Ms ...

Purpose of writing
I am writing in reply to your advertisement in ...
I am writing in order to apply for the position of ...
I would like to apply for the position of ...

Concluding remarks
I hope you will consider my application favourably.
Enclosed please find a photograph of myself.
Please contact me if you require any further information.
I look forward to hearing from you in the near future.

Closing
Yours faithfully,
Yours sincerely,

WRITING A CURRICULUM VITAE

When applying for a job, you will often have to supply the employer with your personal details, as well as your educational qualifications and work experience. Read the model CV below.

MODEL

PERSONAL INFORMATION

Name	FERNÁNDEZ, Juan Antonio
Address	C/ Navas, 6 - 1ºA, Valladolid
Telephone no.	600898776
E-mail	juanaf@hotmail.com
Nationality	Spanish
Date of birth	October 17, 1989

WORK EXPERIENCE

Dates	2005-2007
Name of employer	Burger King
Occupation or position held	Kitchen assistant
Main activities and responsibilities	Food preparation

EDUCATION AND TRAINING

Dates	2005-2007
Name of school	IES San Fernando
Principal subjects covered	Modern languages, history, mathematics
Title of qualification awarded	Secondary School Graduate - Bachillerato

PERSONAL SKILLS AND ABILITIES

LANGUAGES

Mother tongue	Spanish
Other Languages	English (good level written and spoken)
	French (fluent)

COMPUTER SKILLS

General	Microsoft Word, Excel
Graphics or multimedia	Photoshop
Programming	Java for Internet

OTHER SKILLS AND EXPERIENCE 2004-2006, school basketball team
Since childhood – painting, arts and crafts

DRIVING LICENCE Licence for 125cc motorbike

WRITING A DESCRIPTION OF A PLACE

When we describe a place, we want to describe what the place looks like and to give an impression of the atmosphere. Look at the topic below. Then study the plan and read the model.

TOPIC:

Write a description of a place you like.

PLAN:

Opening
Basic information, including the name of the place and its location

Body
Physical characteristics of the place and what there is to do there

Closing
General conclusion, writer's opinion or recommendation

MODEL: The Natural History Museum

One of my favourite places is the Natural History Museum in London. The museum is located in Kensington, close to the Kensington underground station. This museum is a very popular attraction, and for good reason. It's one of the finest museums in the world – and admission is free!

The building itself is architecturally breathtaking, with its impressive ornate façade and enormous central hall. The ceilings, walls and arches are intricately painted and carved with animals and plants, representing the museum's exhibits.

The museum has got two main galleries, the Life Galleries and the Earth Galleries. The Life Galleries offer displays of nearly all living things on earth, from gigantic dinosaurs and huge whales to the tiniest birds and insects. In the Earth Galleries, visitors can explore natural phenomena such as earthquakes and volcanoes and examine thousands of fossils and precious stones.

I highly recommend the Natural History Museum to anyone visiting London. It's more than a museum – it's an experience.

USEFUL LANGUAGE

The first thing people notice ...
It is located ...
The scenery is ...
It offers ...
I can recommend ...
You shouldn't miss ...
I love ... when I go there.
Most people in ... work as ...
In short / conclusion, ...